

Vincent Tirri

3/1/26

Mrs. Lazarski

Audio Visual Production

Early in junior year, when presented with the opportunity to create a project to be showcased at a film festival I became heavily invested. I had originally planned to do a short film, something shorter than most of my other works as a presentational piece for college. However, with personal and teacher judgment, it was decided that I have enough short film work to move into documentary. This is when I pitched my idea of documenting The Sanctuary, a local community hub in Butler, New Jersey. Although the original idea had not changed, ideas and concepts behind what was showcased in the film did. The end result ended becoming a piece that reflected my original idea of how the Sanctuary became a place for emotional freedom and creative expression. The interview portrays the founder Matthew Smith as a caring and selfless individual.

The pre production phase consisted of many tasks. I personally first contacted Mr. Smith and confirmed that his organization would approve of the idea. Then, I focused on script writing and storyboarding. The script went through many drafts and was one of the biggest obstacles in my pre production. I had taken inspiration from The Sanctuary being used in comparison to the famous Sanctuary in *The Walking Dead*, but deemed it didn't have enough relevancy to make the final cut. Eventually, the script was finished and consisted of an intro, outro, five questions, and transitions in between them. With this simple but effective structure I was able to spotlight Mr. Smith and his story rather than creating a narrative piece. After the script was completed, I

finalized storyboards on Celtx, which was simple to do because of the two column script feature to add images. I drew them out on hand first and uploaded the files to match alongside the script. I consider this one of the shining moments of my preproduction process. The next step was creating a shot sheet and equipment list so that I could finally be prepared to move into production. The storyboard consisted of only a few repetitive shots and some specific ideas of B-roll I had pre planned to shoot. My equipment list consisted of gear such as GMX lights, the Lumix camera with a zoom lens, a tripod, ronan, zoom, and lavalier mics. The most challenging and longest part of the pre production process for me was establishing dates and times to film. I wanted my film to show The Sanctuary's variety, so I needed to film multiple days; one day for a concert, one day for a social event, and a time for an interview. The project ended up being delayed weeks as Mrs. Lazarski, Mr. Smith, and I all tried to find working dates. Eventually we landed on two, one that was on November 25th and couldn't film again until February 7th. This is one major obstacle I wish to avoid in the future, and I believe could have been overcome with more considerate planning earlier in the pre production process.

The production process went smoothly with very few limitations setting me back. Overall I believe that the production process had most of my documentaries highlights. From the new lighting techniques I had learned in Co-op to the recording of smooth and clean B-roll on the ronan during the concerts; the ultimate high performance of cinematography I was extremely proud of. However, the shoot was not nearly perfect. Fortunately we had everything needed for set up, but there were a few bumps in the road that we had to overcome. First, we had found out that one of the lights didn't work on a stable level, it either flickered or wouldn't turn on at all. To overcome this we used it as a soft backlight which ended up helping us shoot the shadow in a more professional way. Another issue was that the battery life was much lower than expected and

could have died at any minute. Luckily, it did not, however in the future I plan to pack spare batteries as percussion and always check to make sure the camera is charged before it gets packed away. Shooting went well, the first B-roll day got good coverage of the building and footage of a poetry circle. One issue from this day was the camera shutter was visible in some of the footage, preventing me from using it to great extents. On the second shoot day, all B-roll was shot carefully and along with the interview went smoothly.

The post production phase was the quickest and most efficient phase of my project. Because of complications with SkillsUSA I took the initiative to edit at home to utilize free time wisely. However, this came with a set of challenges I would not have faced in the school environment. My laptop can not run Adobe Premiere Pro as smoothly as school computers can, therefore constant lag and freezing delayed consistent progress in editing sessions. However, I managed in a weekend to complete all major steps of the project. I color corrected, gathered sound bites, and overlaid my cut down B-roll into the sequence. After this, I had recorded my voice over for my introduction, outro, and transitions. My last step was contacting Mr. Smith again to acquire extra B-roll footage from him personally that showcased specific things he talked about outside of or before The Sanctuary. I believe the post production process had the least amount of obstacles, because even with SkillsUSA I managed to work through the slow process of editing on my home computer to edit together a piece I am now proud of.

My favorite part of the production process as a whole was the main production and filming stages. While in most cases post production tends to be a favourite, my lack of enjoyment in cutting soundbites and organizing B-roll, which are distinctive factors of documentaries, ultimately cuts my favoritism short. In the production stage I got to document something I am truly passionate about such as music when I filmed the concert. Being in a place

I was already familiar with and comfortable in, made the production process a lot more inviting to me as a filmmaker. I believe that hearing a story first hand about a place that I know has impacted and changed me for the better, inspired me more to share the story with others as soon as possible. To me that is what art and film in itself is all about. That's why I enjoyed the production phase the most in this specific project.

After completing the project it is evident to me that my strengths resided in my resilience and determination through the obstacles thrown at me, while my weaknesses show through a lack of experience shooting on sets and in timed manors. I believe that although I had my film delayed so long and was forced to edit at home, I never let my passion for the project die out. I believe I can share these strengths by inspiring people to focus their art around something they're already passionate about. A good example of this was a documentary Sheyla made on her dancing journey. Although I may not have been there for the process of its creation, the outcome says enough for you to tell she cared about the film but more importantly the subject it was on. I believe that I can even improve this strength further by not always limiting myself before I even put an idea on paper, and to be less restricting of creative ideas. On the other hand, as previously stated, I felt my main weakness came through on site with being prepared. Setup took longer than it should have, some equipment wasn't working properly, and ultimately it lost a little bit of control. To combat this, I want to work on more crew based roles for films and keep building a habitual mindset of the rights and wrongs that can easily help make a shoot go much faster and cleaner.

Conclusively, I believe my film did a perfect job in meeting its program objective. Mr. Smith talks deliberately about his organization and how it has and continues to help people of all kinds. When people see the documentary, I believe it'll leave an impact on the desired target of

all audiences. As a documentary I truly believe that it serves well in feeding people information about a place in their area they may have never heard of before. The Sanctuary deserves to be known, and I can only hope to be apart of making that reality come true. That's why I am more than glad I created *The Sanctuary For All*.